



Grade 5 Social Studies

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADE 5 · FULL YEAR · THE AMERICAN HISTORIAN-CITIZEN

160 min per week · 2 lessons weekly

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. More sources, maps, and activities are approved for this course than appear here, so scholars may see some variation in materials and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Grade 5 Social Studies forms the American Historian-Citizen. Moving into the dialectic stage, scholars compare perspectives, weigh evidence, deliberate civic questions, and defend historical claims as they travel American history from the first peoples of this continent through colonial America, the Revolution, the Constitution, and westward expansion. Recurring routines — Source Study, Founding Documents, Timeline Thread, Council Chamber, and the Historian's Notebook — train genuine historical judgment, while the Virtue Lens connects the American story to Optima's seven pillars of virtue.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 Tools of the American Historian (Weeks 1–2)

Sources, chronology, and evidence at the fifth-grade level.

3 Early Civilizations and Indigenous Peoples + Synthesis 1 (Weeks 5–11)

Early American civilizations and the Indigenous peoples of North America, closing with Peoples, Places, and Evidence Before Colonization.

5 Colonial America (Weeks 15–18)

The thirteen colonies: daily life, economy, and the roots of self-government.

7 Revolution and Birth of a New Nation (Weeks 24–27)

The war for independence and the founding of the United States.

9 Early Republic and Westward Expansion + Exhibition (Weeks 31–33)

The young nation grows; the year closes with the American Historian-Citizen Exhibition.

2 Geography of North America and the U.S. (Weeks 3–4)

The continent's physical and political geography through map work.

4 First Contact and European Exploration (Weeks 12–14)

Explorers, exchange, and consequences, weighed with sources and maps.

6 Road to Revolution + Synthesis 2 (Weeks 19–23)

Taxes, protests, and founding words, closing with the deliberation Should the Colonies Separate?

8 Constitution and Constitutional Republic (Weeks 28–30)

The Constitution, the branches, and what a constitutional republic asks of its citizens.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- Two social studies lessons each week.
- Lesson A, Enter the Story: background knowledge through readings, maps, images, sources, vocabulary, and guided observation.
- Lesson B, Work of the Historian-Citizen: source comparison, timeline reasoning, council deliberation, founding documents, or notebook synthesis.
- The Virtue Lens runs throughout, connecting the American story to Optima's seven pillars of virtue.

TIME COMMITMENT

160 minutes / week

two lessons a week, about 80 minutes each

- Each week pairs one background lesson with one applied lesson.
- Synthesis weeks ask scholars to gather prior evidence, deliberate, and defend a claim.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A Historian's Notebook (any notebook) for observations, narrations, and evidence.
- Paper and colored pencils for map and timeline work.
- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, meeting twice a week on the school's weekly schedule.